



Piracy: A Sinking Business?

ASEAN ministers reach first major consensus at ASEAN Maritime Forum to combat piracy and Armed Robbery Against Ships (ARAS)



A US Navy ship intercepts a suspected pirate fast craft in the Sulu-Celebes Sea, Philippines on Jul 14, 2023. (Photo: Staff Sergeant Dean W. Wagner, US Navy)

MANILA: The Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) must work together to strengthen mutual intelligence sharing, and put an end to maritime crime, said the Minister of Philippines. "In this area, we must cooperate to stop the violence, (because) pirate crime endangers seafarer lives," he said.

The Minister was in Manila to attend several meetings with ASEAN ministers as the ASEAN Maritime Forum (AMF) held its annual meeting in Philippines' capital Manila. The Philippines is the current rotating chair of ASEAN.

This statement could not have come at a better time. As piracy in the region experiences a surge, heads are turning towards this problem that has long plagued the ASEAN region.

IN THE "SAME ASIA-PACIFIC BOAT", SAYS SINGAPORE

Calling for cooperation in the region, the Minister of Singapore added: "We all share the same Asia-Pacific boat. While each country has its own national conditions, our security and prosperity are intertwined. In the 21st century, a civilised era, we should resolve the issue of piracy with immediacy, through dialogue and consultation."

In the first half of 2025, reported incidents in Asia surged by 83%, with the Straits of Malacca and Singapore serving as the primary hotspot due to their status as vital global shipping lanes carrying about 60% of global trade.

Singapore has since pushed for the Key Initiative of Regional Cooperation (KIRC) framework, which aims to address multiple issues as well as enhance security cooperation while respecting countries' sovereignty.

To address current issues like fragmented information and trust deficits among ASEAN, the KIRC framework aims to standardise reporting protocols, develop non-binding operational guidelines, implement a tiered intelligence-sharing network, and establish a consensus-based consultation forum. These initiatives align with ASEAN's non-interference policy, which is beneficial in maintaining ASEAN's status quo and allowing for the freedom of member states.

PIRACY NO LONGER PAYS

Earlier on Tuesday, the ministers voted on and achieved unanimous consensus on the implementation of the AMF Declaration 1, which they are adopting to address this crisis of the high seas..

The declaration, sponsored by Lao People's Democratic Republic and the Kingdom of Cambodia, aims to establish the ASEAN Central Coastal Development Fund (ACCDF) and push for capacity-building, a two-pronged approach.

The ACCDF is a five-year tapering fund which aims to expedite the development of coastal communities in nine ASEAN nations prone to piracy, with countries providing funding awarded official recognition for smoother business development in beneficiary countries.

Funds will be distributed based on UNdata socio-economic and piracy metrics with the funds being split among coastal infrastructure, income development, and vocational training. Usage will be strictly monitored through mandatory quarterly transparency dossiers.

The declaration also encourages countries with advanced maritime security technology to provide technical assistance to help less developed coastal ASEAN nations for capacity building. Participation is optional as per ASEAN's non-interference policy, but countries are incentivised with faster custom clearances should they choose to provide support.

LOOKING FORWARD

As domestic policies begin to reshape around the fledgling declaration, signatories must consider the true implications of the task at hand. While all is well and good to curate specialised frameworks to tackle piracy, we must remember the real cost of maritime crime.

The real tragedy is the everyday reality that millions of seafarers and innocent bystanders remain in a state of crisis – a tough struggle to preserve their livelihoods, their dignity, and retain a say in their future. And as piracy across Southeast Asia nonetheless continues to rage on, regardless of the declaration signed, the poignant question remains – have we done enough to sink piracy once and for all?